

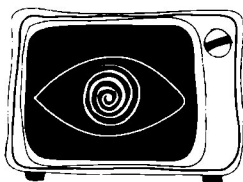
ROUGH CUT KAVEREE BAMZAI

Full Throttle



Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi as a man of history? It seems so, given his attempt to follow his predecessors in the Congress, B.V. Keskar, Lilavati Munshi and Sanjay Gandhi. How, you ask? Well, between 1952 and 1957, the puritanical Keskar banned film music from the then extremely powerful All India Radio (remember television was introduced only in a limited way in 1959, 12 years after Independence). In 1954, 13,000 Delhi homemakers (they were called housewives in those politically innocent times) sent a petition to Jawaharlal Nehru asking him to curb the evil influence of cinema—their cause, as Ramachandra Guha writes in his incisive *India After Gandhi*, was taken up in Parliament by Lilavati Munshi, wife of the even more puritanical K.M. Munshi. She argued in the Rajya Sabha that the “celebration of crime and sex” was encouraging young Indians to repeat these acts in real life—but Prithviraj Kapoor, the great actor who was a member and took his work seriously unlike most representatives from the cultural world now, argued that art could not be throttled because “sunshine and shadows” went hand in hand. Much later, Sanjay Gandhi would order a ban on Kishore Kumar songs on AIR and Doordarshan because he refused to perform at an evening publicising his six point programme—though the official reason was that his songs were obscene.

SAURABH SINGH



The media in India has grown despite, not because of, the government—whether it was the satellite television revolution or Bollywood’s new found global importance. If the government has been unable to draft a broadcast bill, despite 10 years of officially being at it, why should the media industry have to pay with a Draconian content code? For the minister to assume that only those in the government know the larger interests of the nation “in terms of unity, trade and commerce” is to acknowledge in public that it is superior to its citizens, not exactly the best advertisement for a democracy. In an age when dissent, if throttled, finds its own myspace, it is best to leave populist rhetoric behind at popular rallies. After all, when Indira Gandhi introduced colour television in India in 1982, surely she didn’t think it would be used only to broadcast the antics of Appu, the Asian Games’ mascot? And if she did, it is our duty to disabuse her, even if posthumously.

SEEDHI BAAT ON AAJ TAK

“I’m arrogant, I do what I want to do”

FILMMAKER RAM GOPAL VERMA SPOKE TO EDITOR PRABHU CHAWLA about his *Sholay*, remakes and ‘camps’

Q. Why are you remaking *Sholay*?

A. It’s called *Ram Gopal Verma Ki Sholay*. It’s an adaptation of a revenge-based formula like in *Mera Gaon Mera Desh*. It isn’t a remake of *Sholay*. Its character Ghungru is not the character of Basanti and the story is different.

Q. Then why the name *Sholay*?

A. *Rangeela* was a remake of a black and white film. Most of my films are remakes. *China Gate*, *Elan* are also based on *Sholay*. Calling it *Sholay* is negative in a way.

Q. Is your *Gabbar* similar to *Sholay*’s *Gabbar*?

A. My *Gabbar* is very different from *Sholay*’s *Gabbar*. He lives in a city, travels in a car.

Q. What is your philosophy behind making films?

A. There is no philosophy. I do not think about society. I do whatever I want to.

Q. Do you get inspired by your surroundings?

A. Personal observation and experiences reflect in films. A filmmaker is also part of the audience. He makes what he wants to see. I’m not an expert of one emotion.

Q. Were you always interested in filmmaking?

A. I got interested in filmmaking during college. I worked in Telugu films for five years. *Rangeela* was my first Bollywood film.

Q. There are many camps in Bollywood. Which camp do you belong to?

A. Camps are there in all industries. Bollywood is no different. If you cast a star then investors came forward. It’s a business.

Q. You introduce new faces.

A. Because of my arrogance. I like it, so I do it. There is a thin line between arrogance and confidence. If I am successful, it’s called confidence; otherwise it’s arrogance.

Q. What is your current flavour?

A. I’m working with Abhishek and Aishwarya in *Sarkar 2*. The Bachchan family is my current flavour.

Q. Which director is your role model?

A. I don’t believe in good directors. I believe in well-directed films.

Q. What is your mission? To earn more money?

A. My mission is to make films. I don’t have a profit motive. Film is an expensive commercial art. So I wish for hits.

Seedhi Baat is telecast on Aaj Tak at 8.30 p.m. every Sunday and 3.30 p.m. every Monday

Full text of the interview at:

<http://www.indiatoday.com>



MANDAR DEODHAN